



15-minute intervals. If this is the first time in many, many years you will be going through your things, you may need to schedule an hour or two once a week. Parting with junk you've had for years can be tough, so don't overtax yourself. It's not just about the time and effort. It can be an emotional journey.

2. Label three boxes **KEEP**, **UNDECIDED**, and **TOSS**.

Divide your junk into these boxes. This isn't just for the once-every-few-years major clearing. Keep these boxes accessible so that you are constantly maintaining your clutter-free lifestyle. I actually use **KEEP**, **DONATE**, and **TOSS**, because I like to make my decisions straight away.

3. Resist the urge to walk through memory lane.

Don't look through the photo albums, yearbooks, and memory boxes

of old letters and postcards during the first round. Put them in the **KEEP** box and go through them at a later date.

4. Deciding what to get rid of is hard, but it must be done.

We often hold on to things that simply *remind* us of a nice memory. If you bought a useless trinket from your wonderful trip to Paris, take a picture of it to put with the other photos you must have taken on that trip. You don't need to keep the trinket.

Here are some guidelines for determining how to get rid of something:

1. Does this item bring you joy or serve a useful purpose in your life?

Yes = Keep, but decide how to use it more effectively. No = See step 2.

2. Would a photo of the item be sufficient to help you recall fond memories of a person, place, or time?

Yes = Take picture, get rid of item. No = Get rid of item.

Now that you've gone through the process of deciding what you want to get rid of, what are your disposing options?

- Give it to a friend or relative.
- If it's a large object, put it outside with a **FREE** sign (some cities have laws against this).
- Post it on FreeCycle.org.